

The Gap Between Academic Knowledge and Job Market Skills: A Study on Graduate Employability in Bangladesh

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Abstract—This paper compares the gap between knowledge imparted in the university courses and the skills demanded by the job market of the present era particularly in the case of Bangladesh. Despite academic success, a lot of local graduates are having challenges to meet the expectations of employers. This is typically due to excessive theoretical teaching and inadequate experience-based learning in university courses. To examine this problem we carried out a quantitative research through a 14 questions survey with 52 respondents consisting of students and young professionals. The results indicate a definite consensus because 92.3% of the respondents agreed that there is a significant difference between academia and industry. Graduates also revealed a "dual deficit" in their training. They highlighted significant gaps in practical technical skills (53.8%) as well as important soft skills such as communication (32.7%) and teamwork (21.2%). This is because they have not had the practical training while taking classes. The study recommends that universities should change their curriculum. Institutions need to shift from the very theoretical model and begin to incorporate compulsory experiential learning. Emphasis on internships and better relations with corporate employers will ensure that academic results match real-world employer needs.

Index Terms—Academic-industry gap, Curriculum modernization, Experiential learning, Graduate employability, Skill deficiency, Soft skills.

I. INTRODUCTION

A. Background Information

The disconnect between what is taught in school and the professional skills required to get a job is a growing worry in the current workplace. Most universities concentrate on providing theoretical information to the students. Today's employers, however, are looking for graduates to have experience and required professional skills as soon as they enter the workforce. Due to this global disconnect, the curriculum needs to be checked and adapted regularly to meet the evolving needs of the industry and to make students more easily employable [1].

Even with good academic results, many graduates still have a hard time meeting workplace expectations. Employers often point out key areas for improvement, particularly communication, teamwork and problem-solving. According to research, soft skills are now playing a significant part in the hiring

considerations for a graduate. Despite this, there is still a large difference between how students view their mastery of these skills and how important employers think they are [2]. Therefore, students are facing severe problems related to job opportunities after graduating.

It is a particular challenge in Bangladesh. The gap between universities and industry teaching and need makes creates a difficult and competitive environment. Local students are often perceived as not being ready for employment. As a result, employers often prefer to hire expatriate professionals for specialized technical and leadership positions [3]. The answer to this crisis lies in identifying the specific factors that are inhibiting the employability of graduates in the area such as the outdated curriculum design and lack of hands-on practical training [3].

B. Overview

The primary aim of this report is to investigate the perceived mismatch between the theoretical knowledge imparted in university courses and the hard and soft skills needed by the contemporary job market. This study aims to offer strategies that will improve academic achievement to meet industry expectations by providing insights to the students' lack of preparedness in the specific areas. Finally, bridging this divide will take a coordinated approach to the education system. This will directly impact the students, educators and employers.

II. METHODOLOGY

A. Description of the Solution

Technological changes are taking place very fast, and there are continuous developments within the technology industry, therefore, it is imperative that educational institutions keep reviewing their courses and making necessary adjustments [1]. There is a wide gap between education provided by universities and the demands from industries, which is why there is a serious shortage of skills in Bangladesh. This might result in companies preferring foreign specialists to domestic graduates for managerial and technical roles [3].

There are certain steps that should be taken to bridge this employability gap. These include improving the practical skills of students and adjusting the university curricula according to the modern market demands [3]. Adopting methods that enable instructors to identify what knowledge and skills are missing among students helps in preparing them for future career success [1].

B. Methods Used

Primary data was obtained using the quantitative method of survey where the use of questionnaires was employed to find out the existing gaps between academic knowledge and professional requirements. The name of the survey was “Gap between academic knowledge and job market skills” and it was conducted through Google Forms. The survey had 14 questions that were straightforward. There were four sections in the questionnaire; these included basic demographics, learning experience at university, job experiences and issues, and recommendations.

C. Sampling Method

A random sampling method was used for choosing the respondents for this study. The survey was shared by friends, acquaintances and peers via digital communication. This type of random sampling was selected because it has been possible to obtain a representative sample of people who are about to enter the workforce from university. The use of personal and professional networks enabled to quickly capture real-world experiences of existing problems in education and how these directly impact upon employability of graduates.

III. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

A. Results

The primary data that we collected in the 14 question survey provides quantitative evidence of the employability skills gap. There is a very clear consensus among the respondents on their academic preparation and readiness for the workplace.

52 responses

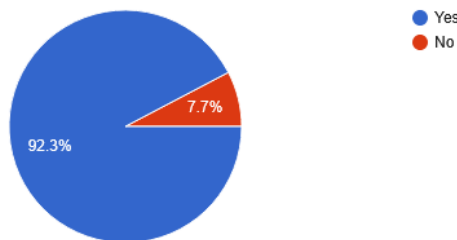


Fig. 1. Student perception of the academic-industry skills gap.

As shown in 1, 92.3% of the respondents agreed that there is a significant difference between what is taught in university and what is demanded in the current job market. Just a small 7.7% said their academic skills were completely in line with what they saw employers expect.

52 responses

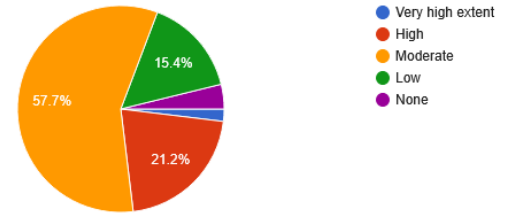


Fig. 2. The level of hands-on and practical learning in current curricula.

As can be seen in Figure 2, there is a lack of experiential learning in academic programs. When we asked about the amount of practical training, 57.7% of respondents indicated that their curriculum offered a “Moderate” amount of hands on learning opportunities. Approximately 21.2% reported their level of practical exposure was a “High” and 15.4% of respondents stated they had a “Low” level of practical integration.

52 responses

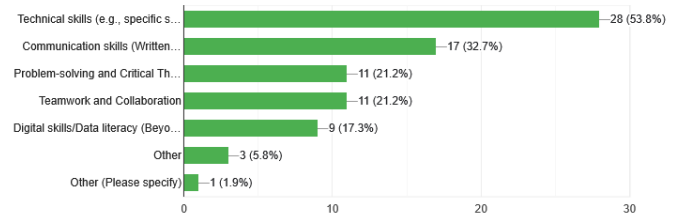


Fig. 3. Recognized areas of weakness in relation to academic training.

As shown in Figure 3, students pointed out the specific areas where their university education fell short. The most common problem that most of the respondents indicated (53.8%) was a lack of technical skills. Lack of soft skills was also notable. The most frequently mentioned were poor communication skills (32.7%), lack of preparation in problem-solving, critical thinking and teamwork/collaboration (21.2%).

52 responses

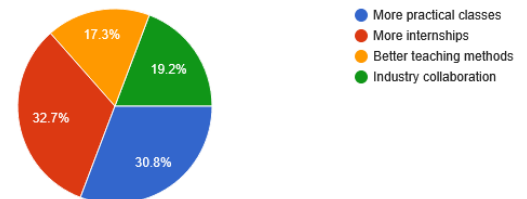


Fig. 4. Student ideas to enhance job readiness.

Figure 4 is a representation of the advice given by the respondents on the actions that universities and other institutions could adopt to better prepare them for work. The largest proportion of the advice was about experiential learning. About 32.7% advocated for internship, and 30.8% believed

that more practical lessons would be required. Other 19.2% believed that participation in the industry is also important.

B. Discussion

The survey results back up the idea that moving from university to the professional workforce is badly slowed down by relying too much on theoretical instruction. The data in 1 clearly shows that the problem is that the degrees are no longer perceived by the students or by employers as a complete signal of preparedness for a job. Next, Figure 3 provides the details of this “dual deficit”. It reveals that the youth who have recently graduated from school are lacking in practical and soft skills that are required for effective team working. Specifically, 53.8% of those surveyed said they lack practical technical skills, and other key workplace attributes, such as communication skills (32.7%), teamwork (21.2%) and problem-solving (21.2%) are considered major weaknesses.

Figure 2 shows the results to give an idea of the root cause of the problem. A majority of students receive very little hands-on experience and when they graduate, they lack the work experience they need to meet the demands of the business world. Systemic changes in the way academics are done are necessary to remedy this gap. Strong demand for hands-on learning makes it clear that universities must shift away from the traditional approach of just memorizing knowledge. The student responses on Figure 4 also directly support this idea, with the most popular suggestions for enhancing universities being to increase the number of internships (32.7%) and increase the number of practical classes (30.8%). Mandatory internships, industry-led workshops, and graded communication projects directly into the syllabus will be vital. Ultimately, addressing the employability gap requires a more robust partnership between the schools and the greater work-based training system to develop a more diverse workforce.

IV. CONCLUSION

A. Limitations

Although this study provides valuable insights into the skills gap in employability, we recognise some methodological considerations. One of the limitations is that the results of the survey may not be representative of all academic departments in Bangladesh because it was a convenience sampling method, meaning that most of the questions were sent to peers and young professionals online. Second, primary data is very much dependent on what students and recent graduates reported on their own. The study does not have direct, quantitative primary data from corporate employers about their actual hiring metrics. Rather, it uses published sources to demonstrate the employer side.

B. Suggestions

Educational institutions must undergo a complete transformation of the way that knowledge is passed on in order to effectively transfer knowledge to the real world and to the employers. It is highly recommended that universities shift away from traditional theoretical models. They need to build in

compulsory experiential learning, such as internships, graded communication projects and industry-led workshops, as a part of their core syllabus. Furthermore, increasing the importance of developing further sustained tie-ups with corporate organizations is needed to keep academic syllabus in line with the technological and business needs of today.

We suggest further research by expanding to larger scale study with direct quantitative industry recruiter feedback. In addition, the impact of the ongoing changes to the curriculum should be assessed over time, providing teachers with a reliable, data-informed approach to systematically address the skill gap and enhance employability.

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

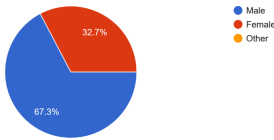
We would like to express our sincere appreciation to all those who have helped in completing this research paper. First of all, we would like to convey our heartfelt appreciation to our course instructor, Mehedi Hasan, Assistant Professor of AIUB, for his guidance and for imparting his knowledge to us. Without his guidance and direction, it would not have been possible to complete this assignment efficiently. Secondly, we are thankful to all those who have participated in our survey. Their response and efforts were very significant in completing this research paper.

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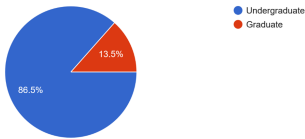
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APPENDIX A
SURVEY RESPONSES

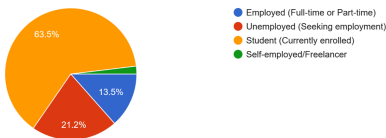
1. What is your gender?
52 responses



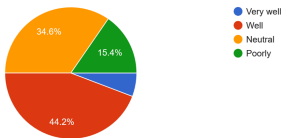
2. What is your highest level of education completed?
52 responses



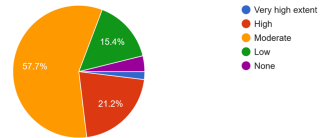
3. What is your current employment status?
52 responses



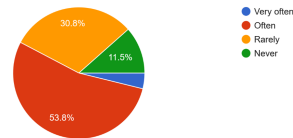
4. How well did your academic program prepare you for essential job-related skills?
52 responses



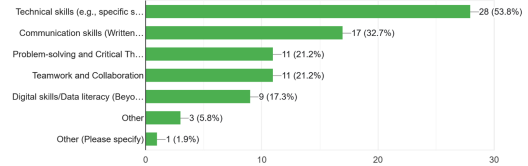
5. How much practical or hands-on learning was included in your curriculum?
52 responses



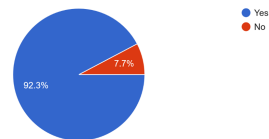
6. How often did you participate in internships or real-world projects during your studies?
52 responses



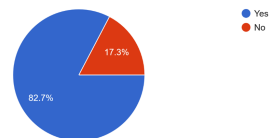
7. Which skills were most lacking in your academic training?
52 responses



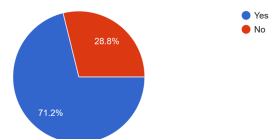
8. Do you think there is a gap between academic learning and job market requirements?
52 responses



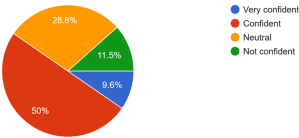
9. Has the lack of practical skills affected your chances of getting a job?
52 responses



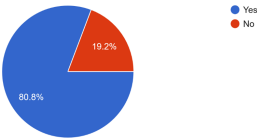
10. Have you faced difficulties in job interviews due to skill gaps?
52 responses



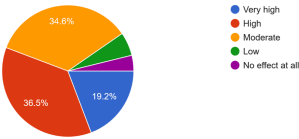
11. How confident are you in performing job-related tasks based on your academic preparation?
52 responses



12. Did you need additional training after graduation to become job-ready?
52 responses



13. How much has the skill gap affected your job performance?
52 responses



14. What do you think universities should do to better prepare students for jobs?
52 responses

